

English Homework: Session 4

Would · Could · Should & Perfect Modals

Student: Ahmet (Gürkan)

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Estimated Time: 1.5 hours

Next Lesson: Saturday / Sunday

Hi Ahmet,

You are making outstanding progress — your fluency and confidence are growing every week. This homework focuses entirely on **modal verbs**: *would*, *could*, *should* and their perfect forms *would have*, *could have*, *should have*. These are some of the most expressive tools in English — they let you talk about advice, regret, possibility, and hypothetical situations. Mastering them will take your speaking to a genuinely advanced level. Let's go! ✓

1 1

Instructions: For each grammar point, (a) study the rule and correction, (b) write one original sentence in the box, and (c) note the rule in your own words below it.

1.1 Grammar Point 1: *Would* — Hypothetical & Polite — past habits

✗ **Common errors:** "I would ~~to~~ go." / "I would ~~going~~ there."

✓ **Correct:** "I would go there if I had the chance."

✓ **Correct (polite):** "Would you like some coffee?" / "I would like to discuss this."

⚡ **Rule:** *Would* is always followed by a **base verb** (no *to*, no *-ing*).

Use it for: (1) hypothetical situations (*If I were you, I would...*), (2) polite requests, (3) past habits (*When I worked at KGM, I would wake up at 6 every day.*)

▷ Write a sentence using *would* about a hypothetical situation in your career or life:

If I were live in the USA I would be a professor at the university.

▷ Write the rule in your own words:

Rule of using 'would' is always followed by a base verb without use any 'to' and 'ing' form. It has 3 form: 1. hypothetical situation (If I were you, I would...) 2. polite request: (I would like to drink...) 3. past habits (when I worked for GDM, I would start for work at 8.30.)

1.2 Grammar Point 2: Could — Ability & Possibility

× **Common errors:** “I can to do it yesterday.” / “Maybe it can happen — we are not sure.”

✓ **Past ability:** “When I was at KGM, I **could** analyse data very quickly.”

✓ **Possibility (present/future):** “AI **could** change road maintenance in the next decade.”

✓ **Polite suggestion:** “You **could** try using a different software for this.”

Rule: Use *could* for: (1) past ability, (2) present/future possibility (softer than *can*), (3) polite suggestions. Always followed by a base verb.

▷ Write one sentence using *could* for past ability and one for future possibility:

1. When I was at high school I could perform at school band. I was into playing drum.
2. She could 'bite the bullet' towards that undesirable situation.

▷ Write the rule in your own words:

use 'could' for 3 situations below,
 1 - past ability 2 - possibility (softer than can) 3 - polite suggestions.
 (Could you please give me a chance again.)

1.3 Grammar Point 3: Should — Advice & Obligation

× **Common errors:** “You should ~~to~~ update the system.” / “Engineers should working more carefully.”

✓ **Advice:** “The government **should** share road data publicly.”

✓ **Expectation:** “The results **should** be ready by Friday.”

✓ **Mild obligation:** “You **should** back up your data every day.”
 hafız sorumlu

Rule: *Should* is always followed by a **base verb**. It is softer than *must* — it gives advice or expresses what is expected, not a strict rule.

▷ Write a sentence giving advice to a young engineer in Turkey using *should*:

young engineers should not concern about salary & workplace conditions
 They should be sure about the team leader's experience and sharing information skills.

▷ Write the rule in your own words:

✓ "We **should have built** a prototype." (*It was the right thing to do — we made a mistake.*)

▷ Think of a project or decision in your career. Write one sentence with **could have** and one with **should have** about that same situation:

1. **could have:** I could have studied my master degree at METU. (I had the option)
2. **should have:** I should have studied for my master degree at METU. (I made a mistake)

2 1

Instructions: Write two short paragraphs (4-5 sentences each). Use **at least three modal structures** from Part 1 in each paragraph. The prompts are based on your own life and career.

Useful Phrase Starters

Looking back, I think I should have ...	If I could have changed one thing, ...
At the time, nobody would have expected...	I could have chosen..., but instead...
In my opinion, young engineers should ...	If the government would only...
One mistake was that I should have ...	With more support, we could ...

Paragraph 1 — Reflection on your career at KGM

Think about your 30 years at KGM. What would you have done differently? What should the organisation have done better? What could have been improved?

Looking back, I think I should have published more international articles.
If I had published more, I would have more citations to be recognised.
One mistake was that KGM should have opened to work with academic missions.
So they could have shared their laboratories with the universities.
Asphalt industry in Türkiye would have been more developed.

Paragraph 2 — Advice to a 35-year-old engineer thinking about starting their own company

Use your experience with Geopave. What should they do? What mistakes could they avoid? What would you have wished someone had told you?

In my opinion a 35-year-old engineer should think about starting their own company. They could have experience in their field if you worked with senior engineer at the big company. Starting their own business they could avoid to afraid for making mistakes. They should have basic knowledge on business life.

3 1

Instructions: Answer each question in 3–5 sentences. Write naturally, as if speaking to someone you just met. **Try to use at least one modal verb in every answer.**

Q1: Is there anything you *could have* done differently when you first started Geopave? What *would* you change if you *could* go back?

When I first started Geopave I could have known more about business management & taxes. If I studied MBA before, I would manage all issues easily. By the way we should share our experience with young engineers.

Q2: Turkey's road network is large and complex. What do you think the government *should* do to modernise road maintenance? What technology *could* help?

In my opinion the government should establish a userfriendly Pavement Management System to prevent their resources. AI technology could help to handle it easier. So data from site could create only analysing the photos of pavement surface. I believe that Mr. Ahsan could establish an amazing one in the near future. :)

Q3: You have a lot of specialised knowledge about pavement engineering. Do you think you *should have* shared more of it publicly earlier in your career? Why or why not?

I have a lot of specialised knowledge about pavement engineering. I think I should have shared more of it publicly earlier in my career. Working for government needs lots of responsibilities I shared with ~~academicians~~ in the past. I wish they have could used those data to establish an efficient PMS.

Q4: Imagine a junior engineer asks you: "Should I stay in my government job, or should I start something on my own?" What would you say to them?

I would say to them you should stay in your government job and continue to increase your knowledge & experience until you would become a senior one. You should spend least 10-15 years at the government with working very hard.

4 1

These words and phrases all work naturally alongside modal verbs. Try to use 4-5 of them in your homework answers above!

Section A — Key Modal Expressions

1. Warm mix asphalt technology must have used to reduce the energy consumption during production of asphalt mixtures.
2. I can't have finished the homework already - it takes more than I expected.
3. The earthquake might have been caused by educational issues.
4. You could have sworn I locked the door.
5. I should have known better this always happens like that.

#	Expression	Example	Notes
1	<i>should have known better</i>	"I should have known better than to trust that contractor."	regret about a bad judgement
2	<i>could have sworn</i>	"I could have sworn the report was finished yesterday."	strong (wrong) belief
3	<i>would have thought</i>	"I would have thought the ministry would share the data."	expectation that wasn't met
4	<i>might have been</i>	"The delay might have been caused by budget issues."	softer possibility in the past
5	<i>ought to</i>	"Engineers ought to document everything carefully."	similar to <i>should</i> — slightly more formal
6	<i>need not have</i>	"We need not have worried — the results were excellent."	unnecessary action in hindsight
7	<i>must have</i>	"The prototype must have impressed the committee."	logical deduction about the past
8	<i>can't have</i>	"He can't have finished the analysis already — it takes days."	impossibility in the past

Section B — Vocabulary for Reflection & Regret

#	Word / Phrase	Example	Synonyms
1	<i>in retrospect</i>	"In retrospect, I should have retired two years earlier."	looking back, with hindsight
2	<i>to overlook</i>	"We could have overlooked a critical flaw in the data."	to miss, to fail to notice
3	<i>to underestimate</i>	"I would never have underestimated the cost if I had more experience."	to misjudge, to miscalculate
4	<i>feasible</i>	"This could have been feasible with a larger budget."	possible, achievable, viable
5	<i>contingency plan</i>	"We should have had a contingency plan for the delay."	backup plan, fallback strategy
6	<i>to foresee</i>	"Nobody could have foreseen how quickly the road deteriorated."	to predict, to anticipate
7	<i>regrettably</i>	"Regrettably, the project should have started six months earlier."	unfortunately, sadly
8	<i>to capitalise on</i>	"We could have capitalised on that government contract."	to make the most of, to exploit
9	<i>transparent</i>	"Data sharing should be more transparent in Turkey."	open, clear, accountable
10	<i>to neglect</i>	"The ministry should not have neglected rural road maintenance."	to ignore, to fail to maintain

Choose 3 words or expressions from the tables above and write one sentence each. Each sentence must contain a modal verb (would / could / should + perfect form if possible).

1. Word / Expression: transparent

Government decision with public life should be more transparent.

2. Word / Expression: to overlook : gözden kaçırmak

The team of construction could have overlooked the details.

3. Word / Expression: to foresee

I couldn't foresee this kind of problems.

Modal	Present / Future	Perfect Form	Use
would	I would do it.	I would have done it.	hypothetical, polite, past habit
could	It could work.	It could have worked.	ability, possibility, suggestion
should	You should try.	You should have tried.	advice, regret, expectation
might	It might happen.	It might have happened.	weak possibility
must	It must be true.	It must have been true.	logical deduction
ought to	You ought to check.	You ought to have checked.	formal advice / duty
need not	You need not worry.	You need not have worried.	unnecessary action